Before You Build

Finding Where You're Needed in Your Community's Hunger Landscape

A 5-Week Course for Community Members Ready to Act

Course Design Document

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For reviewers: This is a course design document for a 5-week community-based program I conceived of and designed. Module 4 is developed to full production depth; other modules are at the objective and activity level. Design notes at the end describe assessment philosophy, accessibility, and key design decisions.

Course Description

You know something needs to be done about hunger in your community. Maybe you've been volunteering at a food pantry and can see the lines getting longer or your neighborhood lost its only grocery store. Maybe you're part of a group that's ready to act but isn't sure where to start.

Before You Build is a 5-week guided exploration for individuals and teams who want to address food insecurity in their communities strategically. Rather than jumping straight to solutions, this course teaches learners to read their community's hunger landscape: to understand what already exists, what's changing, and where the real gaps are, so they can direct their energy where it will matter most.

Learners move from self-assessment through community mapping and systems analysis to produce a Strategic Focus Brief: a document that identifies a specific, evidence-based area of need and articulates why their team is positioned to address it. This deliverable mirrors real-world nonprofit planning and can serve as a foundation for grant applications, board presentations, or coalition-building conversations.

The course is designed for independent learners or small teams working together. No nonprofit experience is required, just the willingness to look carefully before you leap.

One thing to know before you start: People in your community are already working on hunger and food insecurity. This course is designed to enhance your conversations with them, not replace their expertise. Each week includes a team Zoom discussion, and teams are expected to invite a practitioner such as a pantry coordinator, a community health worker, or a SNAP outreach specialist, to react to what the team is learning, share what they've seen, and help keep the work grounded in what the community needs. The assessment tools, mapping exercises, and analysis frameworks in this course produce better outcomes when they're shaped by people with lived experience in the work.

Duration	5 weeks (2–3 hours per week, self-paced)
Audience	Community members, emerging organizers, faith groups, civic teams, or anyone motivated to address local food insecurity
Format	Asynchronous online; works for individuals or cohort groups
Final Deliverable	Strategic Focus Brief identifying a community hunger gap and recommending a direction for action
Prerequisites	None

Course-Level Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, learners will be able to:

1. Identify their personal and team strengths, individual preferences, available resources, and realistic commitment levels for community hunger work.
2. Map existing hunger-related services, programs, and networks within their community, including government, nonprofit, and informal efforts.
3. Consider changing economic, demographic, policy, and environmental conditions that affect food access in their area.
4. Identify specific gaps or underserved populations in their community's food security landscape using evidence gathered through the course.
5. Evaluate potential areas of focus based on community need, existing coverage, and their team's capacity and positioning.
6. Produce a Strategic Focus Brief that synthesizes findings into an actionable recommendation for where to direct effort.

Course Structure

MODULE 1 Week 1	**Starting With You** Self-assessment of motivations, assumptions, capacity, and team strengths.
MODULE 2 Week 2	**Mapping What Exists** Researching and documenting the current hunger-response ecosystem in your community.
MODULE 3 Week 3	**Reading What's Changing** Analyzing emerging factors that are shifting your community's food access landscape.
MODULE 4 Week 4 *Includes outlined learning activities.*	**Finding the Gap** Synthesizing research into gap identification and strategic decision-making.
MODULE 5 Week 5	**From Findings to Focus** Building the Strategic Focus Brief and planning next steps.

Module 1: Starting With You

Week 1 | 2–3 hours

This module grounds learners in honest self-assessment before they look outward. It surfaces assumptions about hunger that could bias their research, establishes a realistic picture of what they and their team can commit to, and begins the relationship with practitioners already doing food insecurity work in the community. Before interpreting their own strengths, learners connect with someone whose experience will shape how they read their assessment results.

Module Objectives:

- Identify personal motivations, assumptions, and potential biases about food insecurity in their community.
- Assess individual and team capacity including time, skills, connections, and resources.
- Articulate a commitment framework that accounts for different energy and availability levels.

Activities:

- **Assumptions Inventory:** Guided reflection surfacing what learners think they know about hunger in their area, then flagging which assumptions are based on evidence and which on perception.
- **Capacity Compass:** Learners use the results from the self-assessment tool to further map their time, skills, connections, and resources. Team version allows members to see collective strengths and gaps.
- **Commitment Tiers:** Learners define their core commitment (always), capacity commitment (when able), and stretch commitment (when conditions allow), establishing sustainable engagement from the start.
- **Practitioner Connection:** Before completing the self-assessment, learners identify and reach out to at least one person already working on food insecurity in their community. The goal is a brief conversation: What does this work actually look like? What roles matter most? What do new groups get wrong? This conversation provides context that shapes how learners interpret their capability assessment results and informs every subsequent module. The practitioner is also invited to the team's weekly Zoom discussion as a recurring guest.
- **Module Deliverable:** Personal or team capacity profile and assumptions log for later comparison against findings.

Module 2: Mapping What Exists

Week 2 | 2–3 hours

Learners shift focus outward to document what's already happening in their community's hunger-response ecosystem. This module prevents duplication of effort and builds the evidence base for later analysis.

Module Objectives:

- Identify and categorize existing hunger-related services including government programs (SNAP, WIC, school meals), nonprofit organizations, faith-based efforts, and informal mutual aid.
- Document service details including populations served, geographic coverage, hours, eligibility requirements, and capacity.
- Create a visual community resource map that reveals patterns of concentration and absence.

Activities:

- **Resource Scavenger Hunt:** Structured research exercise using United Way 211 databases, government program locators, community directories, and direct outreach to build a complete service inventory.
- **Community Map:** Learners plot services geographically (digital or physical map) and annotate with service type, capacity, and access notes.
- **Informational Interview:** Learners conduct one conversation with a person working in local food assistance to learn what's working, what's strained, and what they wish existed.
- **Module Deliverable:** Annotated community resource map and service inventory.

Module 3: Reading What's Changing

Week 3 | 2–3 hours

A static map isn't enough. This module teaches learners to read the forces that are actively reshaping their community's food access landscape, so they can anticipate where needs are headed, not just where they are now.

Module Objectives:

- Identify economic, demographic, environmental, and policy shifts that affect food access in their community.
- Analyze how emerging changes interact with existing services to create new vulnerabilities or opportunities.
- Distinguish between short-term disruptions and structural trends.

Activities:

- **Emerging Factors Scan:** Guided research into local data sources, census data, school free-lunch rates, grocery store openings/closings, housing cost trends, employer changes, to identify what's shifting.
- **Ripple Effect Mapping:** For each major change identified, learners trace its downstream effects on food access. A factory closure doesn't just mean lost income, it may mean lost tax revenue, reduced grocery store viability, and increased demand on food banks simultaneously.
- **Voices from the Ground:** Learners gather at least two perspectives from community members experiencing food insecurity, through conversation, published accounts, or community forum observation, to complement data with lived experience.
- **Module Deliverable:** Emerging factors brief documenting 3–5 significant changes and their projected impact on community food access.

Module 4: Finding the Gap

Module Overview

This is the pivot point of the course. Learners have spent three weeks gathering information, about themselves, about what exists in their community, and about what's changing. Now they synthesize. Module 4 teaches learners to look across their data, identify where services fall short of need, and make a strategic judgment about where their effort belongs.

The module culminates in a branching scenario that simulates the kind of decision a real community team faces: your research points in more than one direction, and you have to choose a focus based on evidence, capacity, and values.

Module Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

- Compare existing services against identified community needs to locate gaps in coverage, access, or quality.
- Distinguish between gaps that represent missing services and gaps that represent barriers to existing services.
- Apply a decision framework that weighs community need, existing coverage, team capacity, and feasibility.
- Articulate a strategic rationale for a chosen area of focus, supported by evidence from prior modules.

Activity 4.1: The Gap Analysis Matrix

Format: Interactive worksheet | **Time:** 45 minutes

Learners compile their findings from Modules 2 and 3 into a structured Gap Analysis Matrix. Using data from their community map and their emerging-factors analysis, they plot existing services against identified needs across key dimensions: geographic coverage, population served, type of food assistance, hours and accessibility, and cultural responsiveness.

The matrix makes visible what's missing. Learners identify at least three gaps, places where community need is not adequately met by current resources.

Deliverable: Completed Gap Analysis Matrix with three or more identified gaps, each supported by at least two data points from previous module work.

Activity 4.2: Service Gap vs. Access Barrier

Format: eLearning interaction (drag-and-drop sorting) | **Time:** 20 minutes

Not every gap means a missing program. Sometimes the service exists but people can't reach it because of transportation, language, stigma, hours of operation, documentation requirements, or lack of awareness. This activity teaches learners to distinguish between two fundamentally different types of gaps, because each calls for a different response.

Learners are presented with 10 community scenarios and sort each into "Service Gap" (no program addresses this need) or "Access Barrier" (a program exists but something prevents

people from using it). After sorting, they receive feedback explaining the distinction for each scenario and why it matters strategically.

Example scenarios:

- A food pantry operates Tuesday 10–noon, when most residents are at work. (Access Barrier)
- No programs address culturally appropriate food for the growing Somali community. (Service Gap)
- A SNAP enrollment office requires documentation that undocumented residents cannot provide. (Access Barrier)

Activity 4.3: The Decision Framework

Format: Guided reflection with scoring rubric | **Time:** 30 minutes

Learners take their identified gaps and evaluate each against four criteria:

- Severity and urgency: How many people are affected? Is this getting worse?
- Current coverage: Is anyone else working on this? How well?
- Team fit: Does your group have the skills, connections, or positioning to make a difference here?
- Feasibility: Can meaningful progress be made with realistic resources and timeline?

Each gap is scored on a simple low/medium/high scale across all four dimensions. The framework doesn't produce a single "right answer" but surfaces the tradeoffs and helps learners articulate why they're choosing one direction over another.

Deliverable: Completed decision framework with written rationale for top-priority gap.

Activity 4.4: Branching Scenario: "Your Team's Crossroads"

Format: Interactive branching scenario (eLearning) | **Time:** 30–40 minutes

Scenario Setup

You are part of a small team of community members in a mid-sized city. Over the past three weeks, you've mapped your community's hunger landscape and analyzed emerging changes. Your research has surfaced two compelling findings:

- The east side of town has become a food desert after a grocery store closure, and no current programs adequately fill the gap.
- Citywide, multiple food assistance programs exist but participation rates among eligible seniors are extremely low due to transportation and technology barriers.

Both are real needs. Your team has limited capacity. You need to choose a direction.

Path A: Address the Food Desert

The learner's team decides to focus on the east side service gap. The scenario guides them through a sequence of decisions:

1. A local church offers space for a weekly distribution. Do you partner with them, knowing their space is only available on Wednesdays? Or do you look for a secular venue that may cost money but offers more flexibility?
2. You discover another group was planning a community garden in the same area. Do you reach out to coordinate, potentially slowing your timeline? Or do you proceed independently to maintain momentum?
3. A city council member offers to help with funding but wants to announce the project at a press event next month, before you're ready. Do you accept the visibility and pressure, or decline and seek funding elsewhere?

Each choice leads to realistic consequences. No path is "wrong," but learners see how decisions about partnerships, pacing, and politics shape what's possible.

Path B: Remove Barriers for Seniors

The learner's team decides to focus on the access barrier. The scenario guides them through:

1. You identify three existing meal programs with low senior participation. Do you approach all three about coordinating outreach, or focus on the one whose staff seems most receptive?
2. A team member suggests door-to-door visits in senior housing to understand barriers firsthand. Another argues this is too time-intensive and you should use existing survey data. Which approach do you take?
3. You learn the biggest barrier is that seniors don't trust programs that ask for personal information. Do you advocate for changing intake procedures (systemic but slow) or create a workaround like a no-questions-asked model (faster but limited)?

Path C: A Hybrid Approach

If learners recognize that their team's findings suggest interconnection, for example, that seniors on the east side face both a service gap and access barriers, they can choose a hybrid path. This route is intentionally more complex, asking learners to manage scope and avoid overcommitment while still addressing root causes.

eLearning note: *This scenario is designed for Storyline branching with 2–3 decision points per path and tailored feedback at each node. The final screen of each path provides a summary of what the team accomplished, what tradeoffs they made, and what questions remain, feeding directly into Module 5's Strategic Focus Brief.*

Module 4 Assessment

Deliverable: Gap Analysis Summary (submitted to course journal)

Learners submit a 1–2 page summary that includes their completed gap analysis matrix, their decision framework scores and rationale, and a reflection on what the branching scenario revealed about their decision-making tendencies. This summary becomes the foundation for the Strategic Focus Brief in Module 5.

Module 5: From Findings to Focus

Week 5 | 2–3 hours

The final module brings everything together. Learners synthesize their capacity assessment, community map, emerging factors analysis, and gap identification into a single Strategic Focus Brief, the course's capstone deliverable.

Module Objectives:

- Synthesize findings from all prior modules into a coherent analysis of community need and team positioning.
- Write a Strategic Focus Brief that could be presented to potential partners, funders, or community stakeholders.
- Identify immediate next steps and the people or organizations needed to move forward.

Activities:

- **Brief Workshop:** Step-by-step guided drafting of the Strategic Focus Brief using a provided template with sections for community context, methodology, key findings, recommended focus area, and rationale.
- **Peer Review (cohort version):** Teams exchange briefs and provide structured feedback on clarity, evidence strength, and feasibility. Solo learners complete a self-review checklist.
- **Next Steps Roadmap:** Learners identify 3–5 concrete actions for the 30 days following course completion: who to contact, what to learn more about, and what first small step to take.
- **Module Deliverable:** Completed Strategic Focus Brief and 30-day action roadmap.

Design Notes for Reviewers

Assessment philosophy: This course uses authentic assessment throughout. There are no quizzes or knowledge checks divorced from application. Every deliverable is something the learner would actually use, such as a capacity profile, a resource map, an analysis, or a strategic document. The branching scenario in Module 4 assesses analytical thinking through simulated decision-making rather than recall.

Scalability: The course functions for a single motivated individual or a team of three to eight people working through it together. Group activities have solo alternatives. The cohort model adds peer learning and diverse perspective but is not required.

eLearning development: Module 4 is designed for full interactive development in Articulate Storyline, with the branching scenario (Activity 4.4) and the drag-and-drop sorting exercise (Activity 4.2) as primary interactive elements. Other modules could be developed as eLearning or delivered as facilitated workshops with the same core structure.

Accessibility considerations: All activities include alternative formats. Visual mapping exercises accept text-based alternatives. Time estimates are flexible. The commitment tiers framework in Module 1 establishes from the outset that different participation levels are valid.

Practitioner engagement: The course is built on the premise that community action teams should learn alongside people already doing the work, not in isolation from them. Weekly Zoom discussions include a standing invitation for a practitioner, someone with direct experience in food insecurity response, to react to the team's findings, challenge assumptions, and share practical knowledge. This is not a guest speaker slot; it is a recurring relationship that deepens over the five weeks. The practitioner's input shapes how learners read their capability assessments, interpret their community maps, and evaluate potential areas of focus. Module 2's Informational Interview and Module 3's Voices from the Ground activities formalize this posture, but the weekly Zoom conversations make it structural rather than episodic.